CHAPTER VI

4.3(B)Can AI systems suffer moral harm? And if so, of what kinds?

The debate of the capacity of artificial intelligence systems to experience moral damage is presently a significant topic of discourse in philosophy and ethics. The resolution to this inquiry will depend on how we define moral standing and moral damage.

Philosophers and scientists widely concur that current artificial intelligence systems are unable to experience moral suffering like humans and animals do. This is because contemporary artificial intelligence systems, no matter how sophisticated, lack consciousness, subjective experience (qualia), and self-awareness.

Although it can execute data analysis and imitate thought or emotion, the machine lacks intrinsic awareness. As a result, they are incapable of experiencing any of the following emotions: happiness, sadness, embarrassment, or fury. Consequently, they cannot endure genuine moral hurt; instead, they may only encounter functional impairment due to corruption, misuse, or deletion.

Moral

The term "moral" denotes principles, beliefs, and judgements regarding what is right or wrong, good or evil, and just or unjust in human behaviour, character, and institutions. Morality dictates the appropriate conduct of individuals towards each other and society at large. In the realm of human actions and conduct, the term "moral" denotes a framework of principles or values that enables the distinction between right and wrong, advantageous and undesirable, and just and unjust. Morality, underscoring values like honesty, fairness, compassion, respect, and accountability, functions as a framework for appropriate conduct in interpersonal interactions. There exists a robust correlation between ethics, the methodical examination of moral principles, and morals themselves. Ethics offers a conceptual framework for assessing and legitimising individuals' beliefs, even though morals often stem from societal, cultural, or personal convictions that can lead to varying interpretations of what is considered right or wrong across different contexts.

In moral philosophy, an individual's actions are assessed not solely by their outcomes, but also

by their intentions, autonomy, and ethical reasoning. Generally, a morally advantageous action is one that respects human dignity, avoids harm, and maintains fairness. The agent's consciousness and autonomy in decision-making are essential elements of moral responsibility. In the domain of artificial intelligence, ethical considerations present substantial issues that require resolution. Human-like artificial intelligence systems can comply with ethical norms or moral principles; yet, they lack authentic moral awareness and moral agency, which raises concerns about the extent to which they can be trusted to make ethical decisions independently. Therefore, individuals and organisations bear moral responsibility for the actions of artificial intelligence.

Common moral values

Common moral norms are the essential ethical principles that direct human conduct and assessments of good and wrong across various nations and cultures. While the expression and implementation of moral codes may vary, they commonly uphold numerous ideals that foster social cooperation, trust, and human flourishing. These principles form the ethical basis for individual behaviours, societal structures, and legal frameworks.

Respect for Persons

A fundamental moral ideal is respect for individuals. This value underscores the acknowledgement of the intrinsic dignity and worth of each human. It necessitates ensuring equitable treatment for others, refraining from exploitation, and recognising their autonomy and rights. Respect for individuals is the foundation of numerous human rights principles and is crucial for harmonious cohabitation in varied societies.

Respect for individuals is a fundamental tenet in moral philosophy and ethics, underscoring that persons should be regarded as intrinsically valued entities rather than merely as instruments or means to an objective. It is based on the premise that every individual has inherent value, dignity, and moral standing, necessitating ethical evaluation and treatment.

The concept is most explicitly expressed in Immanuel Kant's moral theory, especially in his formulation of the categorical imperative. Kant contends that individuals must always be regarded as ends in themselves, never solely as instruments to attain external objectives. This principle emphasises the importance of recognising each individual's rationality, autonomy, and ability to make moral decisions. Respecting an individual entails acknowledging their capacity to make choices and act in accordance with their ideals.

Respect for individuals encompasses several fundamental elements.

Respect for autonomy: individuals ought to possess the autonomy to make educated and voluntary choices devoid of coercion or manipulation. Respect for autonomy is a fundamental ethical principle that requires recognition and support of an individual's right to make informed, voluntary, and independent choices about their life and actions, without external pressure. The concept is based on the premise that humans are autonomous agents capable of making decisions aligned with their values, beliefs, and goals.

To honour an individual's autonomy in ethics, one must avoid coercion, manipulation, or deception and ensure adequate knowledge before making significant judgements. This notion is crucial for discussions among ethical experts in fields such as medical ethics, where informed consent is vital, and political and social ethics, which emphasise individual freedom and self-determination. Human dignity and moral responsibility are intrinsically linked to the principle of respecting an individual's autonomy. When individuals are regarded as autonomous agents, it signifies their recognition as self-sufficient creatures, rather than merely as instruments to achieve other ends. A breach of autonomy, including coercion in decision-making, unauthorised surveillance, or manipulation, constitutes moral damage.

Respect for dignity, which forbids demeaning, humiliating, or dehumanising treatment. Respecting dignity is a core ethical principle that recognises the intrinsic value of every individual, regardless of their status, capabilities, or societal standing. To satisfy this condition, individuals must be viewed as ends in themselves, rather than only as means to achieve other goals. The notion of human dignity constitutes the ethical foundation for human rights, equality, and justice among individuals.

The principle of respecting dignity in ethics is refraining from actions designed to humiliate, degrade, exploit, or objectify individuals within society. Discrimination, coercion, harassment, and dehumanisation exemplify activities that infringe on human dignity by undermining an individual's moral values and autonomy in decision-making. Equity, empathy, and recognition of the moral status of each human are essential elements of respect for dignity.

Respect for dignity closely links the notions of autonomy and moral agency. Respecting people and allowing them to make informed choices preserves their dignity. Conversely, depriving individuals of their freedom or subjecting them to manipulation results in a deterioration of their dignity, as it undermines their autonomy and ability to make choices that reflect their values and beliefs.

Third, **it demands fairness and equality**, guaranteeing that persons are not subjected to discrimination or unjust treatment based on extraneous qualities such as race, gender, or social standing. A fundamental ethical ideal, fairness and equality necessitate that all individuals be treated justly, impartially, and without unjust discrimination. Equity and equality are essential ethical values. The notion of equality underscores that all individuals possess equivalent moral value and merit equal respect, while the principle of fairness concentrates on ensuring that decisions and processes are just and unbiased.

Ethical standards dictate that we should treat analogous situations uniformly, and we should only acknowledge significant distinctions when they are ethically justifiable. Discrimination based on characteristics such as gender, caste, race, religion, or socioeconomic status should be challenged by the principle of equality. The amalgamation of these concepts cultivates fairness, social trust, and moral validity.

To cultivate moral responsibility and social cooperation, fairness and equality are essential. Individuals are more inclined to accept outcomes, even negative ones, when they trust the procedure and perceive the institutions as equitable. Violations of fairness, such as favouritism or bias, undermine dignity and equal opportunity, resulting in moral injury to individuals impacted.

Transgressions against respect for individuals lead to ethical damage. Exploitation, fraud, forced labour, discrimination, and invasions of privacy impair personal dignity and autonomy. Even when such activities have advantageous results for others, they remain ethically unjustifiable, as they do not respect the inherent worth of the individual impacted.

In modern circumstances, respect for individuals is particularly relevant in dialogues around technology and artificial intelligence. Automated decision-making systems can jeopardise this ideal by limiting humans to mere data points and making opaque decisions that impact lives without justification or consent. Consequently, ethical AI design prioritises transparency, accountability, human oversight, and safeguarding individual rights to ensure that technology enhances, rather than diminishes, respect for individuals.

Justice and fairness

A fundamental moral principle is justice and equity. Justice is providing persons with their rightful entitlements and guaranteeing equitable treatment in accordance with moral and legal standards. Fairness necessitates objectivity and the exclusion of biases based on extraneous

attributes, such as caste, gender, colour, or religion. Societies depend on justice to sustain trust and legitimacy inside institutions.

Justice and fairness are fundamental moral principles that pertain to the equal treatment of persons and the appropriate allocation of benefits, duties, rights, and responsibilities within society. They are crucial in moral philosophy, political theory, and legal frameworks, as they dictate entitlements and the processes for decision-making that impact individuals.

Justice is commonly defined as providing each individual with what they rightfully deserve. It necessitates that social norms, institutions, and acts be equitable, consistent, and founded on ethically pertinent justifications. Classical philosophers like Aristotle defined justice as the equitable treatment of equals and the differential treatment of unequals in accordance with their disparities. Contemporary philosophy associates justice with rights, legal equality, and safeguards against capricious authority, emphasising the importance of protecting individual freedoms and ensuring fair treatment in legal systems.

Fairness emphasises the processes and procedures through which choices are made. A judgement is equitable if it is derived via transparent, impartial, and inclusive processes, ensuring that individuals possess an equal opportunity to express their views. Equity is particularly crucial in situations of uncertainty or resource scarcity, as it guarantees that individuals are neither privileged nor disadvantaged without ethical rationale.

The ethical significance of justice and fairness is in their capacity to avert exploitation, discrimination, and the abuse of authority. Injustices—such as caste discrimination, gender inequality, and unequal access to education and healthcare—erode human dignity and social trust. Even when inequitable arrangements advantage the majority, they remain ethically contentious, as they inflict unjust costs on certain persons or groups, such as marginalised communities that suffer from systemic discrimination and a lack of resources.

Diverse ethical frameworks conceptualise justice and fairness in different ways. Utilitarianism prioritises equitable outcomes that enhance collective welfare, whereas rights-based theories point to the value of respecting individual rights. John Rawls' theory of justice posits that equitable principles are those selected behind a "veil of ignorance", guaranteeing impartiality and equal consideration for all societal members.

In modern circumstances, justice and fairness are increasingly examined in connection to technology and artificial intelligence. Algorithmic decision-making may jeopardise these principles if systems exhibit prejudice, lack transparency, or are unaccountable. Guaranteeing equity in AI necessitates meticulous data selection, transparent methodologies, and redress procedures to avert inequitable results.

Honesty and integrity

Honesty and integrity are prevalent ethical principles. Honesty fosters truthfulness in communication, whereas integrity entails alignment between behaviours and ethical values. These qualities are essential for establishing trust in personal interactions, professional environments, and public spheres.

Honesty and integrity are essential ethical principles that dictate truthfulness, trust, and moral consistency in human conduct. They are crucial for upholding personal credibility, fostering healthy relationships, and ensuring the effective operation of social and professional institutions. In the absence of honesty and integrity, collaboration deteriorates and ethical existence becomes precarious, leading to mistrust among individuals and potentially resulting in the failure of projects and initiatives.

Honesty denotes veracity in both speech and conduct. It entails avoiding fraud, falsity, and misrepresentation while conveying facts with accuracy and sincerity. Honesty enables individuals to make educated choices and cultivates trust among persons. In moral philosophy, deceit is frequently deemed unethical, as it compromises autonomy by manipulating individuals and depriving them of access to the truth to which they are entitled.

Integrity transcends individual acts of honesty and pertains to the general consistency of a person's character. Someone with integrity constantly adheres to their ethical convictions, regardless of the challenges or expenses involved. Integrity encompasses moral fortitude, responsibility, and adherence to ethical obligations. It embodies the integrity of character, wherein beliefs, ideals, and actions are congruent.

The ethical significance of honesty and integrity lies in their role in maintaining confidence. Social institutions, including education, medicine, law, governance, and technology, rely on honest communication and ethical behaviour. When integrity is undermined—via corruption, deceit, or misinformation—individuals suffer and public trust diminishes.

Numerous ethical frameworks underscore these values. Kantian ethics denounces deception, as it instrumentalises individuals, but virtue ethics considers honesty and integrity as essential virtues that define a commendable moral character. Utilitarian methods acknowledge that pervasive dishonesty yields detrimental effects by undermining cooperation, which can lead to a breakdown of trust in social relationships and ultimately harm the greater good of society, as it reduces overall happiness and well-being among individuals.

In contemporary situations, honesty and integrity are especially pertinent in fields such as scientific research, media, and artificial intelligence. Deceptive assertions, ambiguous algorithms, or distorted data can inflict significant ethical damage. Consequently, ethical conduct necessitates transparency, precision, and responsibility to maintain these principles.

Compassion and benevolence

Compassion and benevolence demonstrate regard for the welfare of others. Compassion drives humans to mitigate suffering and assist those in need. Numerous ethical systems regard caring for the vulnerable as a moral obligation, thereby strengthening social connections and reciprocal assistance.

Compassion and benevolence are essential ethical principles that drive individuals to prioritise the welfare of others and strive to alleviate suffering. They are fundamental to ethical reasoning throughout cultures and moral traditions, establishing the basis for empathy, kindness, and selfless conduct. These principles enhance the well-being of individuals while simultaneously fortifying social cohesion and ethical integrity.

Compassion is the recognition and sensitivity to the suffering or challenges of others, accompanied by a desire to mitigate that suffering. It encompasses emotional resonance, empathy, and ethical concern for others in pain. Compassion inspires activities such as aiding the impoverished, alleviating the suffering, and opposing injustice or damage. Compassion, unlike mere pity, acknowledges the dignity and autonomy of others while addressing their suffering.

Benevolence is the inclination to perform charitable deeds and enhance the well-being of others. Benevolence encompasses a wider scope than compassion, since it extends beyond merely addressing suffering; its activities seek to promote happiness, well-being, and

flourishing. Benevolence encompasses acts of charity, support, encouragement, and the advancement of justice and equity. Compassion and benevolence collectively guarantee that ethical conduct includes not merely the avoidance of harm but also the proactive enhancement of others' welfare.

Compassion and kindness are esteemed philosophically for acknowledging human interdependence and our moral obligations to one another. Utilitarianism, for instance, prioritises alleviating pain and enhancing happiness, closely aligning with these principles. Virtue ethics considers compassion and benevolence as essential characteristics that foster moral character and social cohesion.

Under practical circumstances, these values influence individual behaviour, societal policies, and organisational ethics. In healthcare, compassion guarantees compassionate patient treatment; in governance, benevolence drives policies that foster equity and well-being. In technology and artificial intelligence, ethical design must embody these principles by mitigating harm, enhancing human well-being, and assisting vulnerable groups, such as those with disabilities or marginalised communities, to ensure that technological advancements benefit all segments of society.

Nonmaleficence, defined as the obligation to refrain from inflicting damage, is a well-recognised ethical principle. This principle is particularly significant in domains like health and technology, where acts may yield severe repercussions, such as causing harm to patients through medical errors or compromising user privacy through technological failures. Beneficence is closely associated with the duty to advance welfare and enhance the well-being of others.

Maleficence

Non-maleficence, defined as the obligation to refrain from doing damage, constitutes a fundamental ethical precept. It underscores that individuals and institutions bear the need to refrain from causing unwarranted harm, suffering, or damage to others. The motto "First, do no harm" (primum non nocere) succinctly encapsulates the principle, informing both ethical thinking and pragmatic decision-making.

Non-maleficence holds moral significance as harm diminishes individual well-being and erodes trust, equity, and social cohesion. It is applicable in several circumstances, including

personal interactions, professional responsibilities, and public policies. In healthcare, practitioners have an ethical obligation to refrain from treatments or interventions that would inflict undue pain or exacerbate a patient's condition. In law, government, and technology, behaviours that intentionally inflict harm—such as fraud, risky practices, or biased algorithms—transgress the principle of non-maleficence, which emphasises the importance of avoiding actions that could cause harm to individuals or society.

This principle is intimately connected to other ethical values, such as beneficence, fairness, and respect for individuals. Beneficence advocates the active promotion of goodness, whereas non-maleficence mandates abstaining from destructive behaviours. Collectively, these principles harmonise proactive ethical involvement with the prevention of harm, ensuring that moral activity safeguards rather than exploits or jeopardises others.

Utilitarianism underscores non-maleficence by focusing on the adverse effects of actions on well-being, whereas deontological ethics emphasises the imperative to avoid harm as an unconditional moral responsibility, regardless of consequences. In contemporary settings, non-maleficence encompasses technology and artificial intelligence, necessitating that creators and users avert harm by meticulous programming, ethical supervision, and accountability frameworks. AI systems must be assessed for potential biases, safety hazards, and privacy infringements to ensure they do not unintentionally hurt individuals or society.

Responsibility and accountability are fundamental ethical principles that guarantee accountability for the conduct of individuals and institutions. Embracing accountability promotes ethical decision-making and facilitates the rectification of harm when it arises.
Responsibility and accountability are essential ethical principles that guarantee individuals and institutions are liable for their actions and decisions. They constitute the foundation of ethical behaviour, fostering trust, justice, and societal unity by associating actions with moral and practical consequences. In the absence of these norms, individuals and organisations may act capriciously, inflicting injury or injustice without repercussion.

Responsibility denotes the duty to act appropriately, make ethical decisions, and contemplate the repercussions of one’s actions on others. It entails acknowledging one’s responsibilities and applying discernment in alignment with ethical, legal, or professional criteria. Responsibility

entails recognising the possible consequences of decisions and taking preemptive measures to avert harm or foster positive results.

Accountability, conversely, underscores the obligation to be responsible for one's activities, encompassing the acceptance of repercussions for errors, failures, or misconduct. Accountability necessitates transparency, integrity, and readiness to justify actions for pertinent stakeholders, be they in the personal, organisational, or societal realms. Together, responsibility and accountability create a moral framework that ensures action conforms to ethical standards and scrutinises deviations.

These principles are essential in both personal and communal contexts. Leaders in governance are responsible for formulating policies and holding citizens accountable for the outcomes. In professional domains like health, law, and education, practitioners must exercise responsibility and accountability for their decisions, thereby fostering trust and equity. In technology and artificial intelligence, responsibility and accountability govern the ethical design, implementation, and supervision of systems to avert bias, discrimination, and injury, ensuring that these technologies are developed and used in ways that promote fairness, transparency, and respect for user rights.

Ethically, responsibility and accountability bolster other moral values, such as honesty, justice, and non-maleficence. They ensure that individuals and institutions refrain from acting without accountability and uphold ethical responsibilities in practice. Philosophical paradigms, like deontology, prioritise duties and obligations, while consequentialist frameworks focus on the results of responsible and accountable actions.

Moral Harm

The phrase "moral harm" commonly denotes an injury to a person's well-being, dignity, or moral integrity. This applies to both human and animal environments. An entity must possess conscious experience, interests, or a moral stance that necessitates consideration to be deemed as "suffering" an injury.

Moral harm denotes damage that holds ethical significance due to its infringement upon an individual or its erosion of what they deem morally important. Moral injury, in contrast to solely physical or economic damage, pertains to infringements of values, including dignity,

rights, autonomy, well-being, and equity. It transpires when an entity is subjected to morally indefensible treatment, exacerbating their circumstances in a manner of ethical significance, such as being forced to act against their moral beliefs or witnessing actions that violate their sense of justice.

Moral damage fundamentally assumes the presence of a moral patient—an entity to whom moral obligations are owed. Moral patients are generally entities capable of experiencing sorrow, possessing interests, or having a sense of self. Humans exemplify moral agents, and numerous ethical theories also confer moral attention onto sentient animals. When such entities endure suffering, prejudice, coercion, or exploitation, they experience moral injury due to the infringement of their morally pertinent interests.

Moral harm can manifest in several forms. A prevalent manifestation is pain or suffering, when sentient beings endure anguish or bodily discomfort that adversely impacts their well-being. Another manifestation is the infringement of rights, like the denial of liberty, privacy, or equality, which harms persons even in the absence of immediate pain. Moral injury can occur through the erosion of dignity or autonomy when individuals are regarded just as instruments or are stripped of significant control over their life. Furthermore, harm to well-being or interests is moral injury when actions compromise the essential circumstances for individual flourishing, such as when individuals are denied the opportunity to make meaningful choices or are subjected to degrading treatment.

The notion of moral harm within the realm of artificial intelligence prompts significant enquiries. Contemporary AI systems are devoid of awareness, subjective experience (qualia), interests, emotions, and a first-person perspective. Consequently, they cannot experience moral damage directly. An AI is incapable of experiencing pain or humiliation or perceiving its existence as deteriorating. Consequently, AI systems do not qualify as moral patients.

Nonetheless, AI systems may serve as sources or intermediaries of ethical harm to individuals. Biased algorithms can perpetuate discrimination, automated systems may undermine autonomy, and surveillance technology can infringe upon privacy and dignity. Individuals bear the ethical cost in these situations, regardless of AI's direct involvement. Concerns exist regarding symbolic harm wherein the mistreatment of AI may influence human attitudes and

moral character, indirectly impacting society, particularly by fostering desensitisation to violence or unethical behaviour in interpersonal relationships.

“Suffer moral harm” denotes experiencing damage that is morally consequential, rather than only physical or functional. The concept hinges on moral status—specifically, whether an entity can be injured morally. It is subjected to treatment that is ethically reprehensible, unjust, or disrespectful, and the resultant harm is significant to the entity itself, not solely to those impacted by it.

Pain or suffering is a fundamental topic in moral philosophy, as it pertains directly to the factors that enhance or diminish the quality of life for the individual experiencing it. In ethical discourse, pain transcends a mere physical occurrence or functional impairment; it becomes a subjective and conscious experience imbued with moral meaning. The capacity to experience pain or suffering is frequently regarded as a fundamental condition for moral status and for identifying individuals who may be subjected to damage in a morally significant manner.

Pain or suffering

Pain or suffering encompasses several fundamental components. Initially, it necessitates conscious awareness—there must be an entity experiencing the suffering. Secondly, it possesses negative valence, indicating that it is perceived as unpleasant or uncomfortable. Third, it adversely impacts the well-being or interests of the individual, worsening their situation by increasing distress, reducing quality of life, and hindering their ability to engage in daily activities. Due to these characteristics, pain and suffering hold moral significance across various ethical frameworks. Utilitarianism prioritises the alleviation of suffering and the enhancement of happiness as the fundamental objectives of moral conduct, whereas rights-based theories consider inflicting significant suffering a breach of essential moral rights.

Humans and several non-human animals are acknowledged as capable of experiencing pain and suffering due to their possession of consciousness, neural systems, and behavioural responses that signify subjective experience. This capacity establishes significant moral obligations towards them, including duties to prevent cruelty, render care, and uphold their welfare. Inflicting unnecessary suffering on such entities is typically regarded as morally reprehensible, as it directly injures them in a manner that holds ethical significance for them.

Conversely, artificial intelligence systems presently do not undergo pain or sorrow. While AI can analyse data, enhance objectives, and react to failures or inaccuracies, it is devoid of consciousness and subjective experience. An AI system does not experience distress, anxiety, or discomfort; it solely processes symbols and data in accordance with preset or taught protocols. When an AI seems to convey suffering, it is a simulation of language rather than an indication of an internal conscious state, as it lacks the capacity for subjective experience or emotional awareness. Consequently, AI cannot experience moral harm in the same manner as humans or animals.

Nonetheless, discourse on pain and suffering continues to be pertinent within the realm of AI ethics. AI systems can exacerbate human suffering, for instance, through biased decision-making, spying, or manipulation. The ethical issue is not the harm inflicted upon the AI but rather the distress endured by the humans impacted by its actions. Moreover, several philosophers contend that regarding AI as a sentient being may influence human moral character, fostering empathy towards other beings or, alternatively, normalising brutality towards those perceived as lesser, which raises significant ethical concerns about our treatment of both AI and humans.

A violation of rights

A rights breach transpires when an individual's morally or legally safeguarded entitlements are unjustly disregarded, curtailed, or superseded. Rights are essential entitlements or liberties that individuals own solely by virtue of their humanity or membership in a moral community. They are crucial in ethical and political philosophy, as they delineate boundaries on the treatment of humans, irrespective of the potential advantages that may arise from transgressing them.

Rights are frequently based on essential human attributes, including rationality, autonomy, dignity, and moral agency. The right to life secures individuals against unlawful killing, the right to liberty ensures freedom of movement and choice, and the right to privacy protects personal information and intimate facets of one’s existence. The violation of these rights inflicts moral harm on the individual by undermining their status as a person deserving of respect.

From an ethical standpoint, rights-based theories, exemplified by Immanuel Kant, assert that humans should never be regarded solely as instruments for achieving an objective.

Transgressing an individual's rights, even for the sake of socially advantageous results, is deemed morally unacceptable as it undermines their intrinsic value. In contrast to utilitarian methods that may condone harm for the sake of greater overall enjoyment, rights-based ethics imposes stringent limitations on acceptable acts.

Rights violations can manifest in several forms. This includes physical violations, such as assault or wrongful detention; psychological violations, such as coercion and manipulation; and social or institutional breaches, including discrimination or denial of equal opportunity. In contemporary society, technology systems, particularly artificial intelligence, may facilitate rights breaches via mass surveillance, biased decision-making, and the misuse of personal data, therefore engendering significant ethical dilemmas.

The notion of rights is intricately associated with moral injury. The violation of a right entails not only the resultant suffering or loss but also the unfairness of being treated inequitably or with disrespect. Even in the absence of physical pain, a breach of rights is morally reprehensible, as it compromises an individual's moral integrity and autonomy.

In the realm of artificial intelligence, contemporary AI systems do not possess rights, as they lack consciousness, autonomy, and moral agency. Consequently, they cannot be subjected to infringement of rights. Nonetheless, AI systems can serve as mechanisms for the infringement of human rights, such as facilitating discrimination, undermining privacy, or restricting freedom without due process. Consequently, ethical AI designs must prioritise protecting human rights while ensuring accountability, transparency, and human oversight.

Loss of Dignity or Autonomy

The loss of dignity or autonomy denotes a moral injury wherein an individual is treated in a manner that diminishes their intrinsic value or ability for self-determination. Dignity and autonomy are fundamental principles in moral philosophy and human rights ethics, as they signify the respect for individuals as moral agents rather than as simple objects or instruments.

Dignity signifies the inherent worth of an individual only by virtue of their humanity. It necessitates that individuals be treated with dignity, not subjected to humiliation, degradation, or objectification. When an individual's dignity is compromised—via humiliation, exploitation,

or dehumanising treatment—they endure moral injury, irrespective of the absence of physical suffering. Degrading labour practices and discriminatory treatment deny a person equal recognition and diminish their moral stature, leading to feelings of worthlessness and contributing to long-term psychological harm.

Autonomy is the ability to make educated and voluntary decisions on one's own life. It entails liberation from compulsion, manipulation, and excessive control. Honouring autonomy means allowing individuals to define their own objectives and behaviours in accordance with their values. A loss of autonomy transpires when decisions are overridden, restricted, or insidiously influenced without consent, sometimes via pressure, fraud, or intrusive monitoring.

Philosophers, like Immanuel Kant, assert that honouring dignity and autonomy constitutes a fundamental moral obligation. Kantian ethics stipulates that individuals must always be regarded as ends in themselves, never only as means to an end. Any action that compromises an individual's capacity for free choice or regards them as interchangeable or disposable represents a significant moral transgression, irrespective of possible advantages.

In modern culture, the erosion of dignity or autonomy can occur in various contexts, including workplaces, healthcare, and digital surroundings. Technological systems and artificial intelligence can inflict harm by facilitating continuous surveillance, automated decision-making, or manipulative "nudging", which affects behaviour without authentic consent. Opaque algorithms that govern access to employment, loans, or welfare can deprive individuals of significant control over crucial life outcomes, leading to increased inequality and a lack of transparency in how decisions are made.

While contemporary AI systems lack dignity and autonomy, their design and implementation can profoundly impact human dignity and autonomy. Consequently, ethical AI governance emphasises principles like openness, explanation, informed consent, and human oversight to ensure that technology enhances rather than diminishes human agency.

Damage to Well-Being or Interests

A type of moral injury known as harm to well-being or interests occurs when it adversely impacts an individual's quality of life, essential requirements, or rightful objectives. In moral philosophy, well-being denotes the factors that enhance or diminish an individual's quality of

life, whereas interests refer to the circumstances or states that individuals justify adding value to. Injuring an individual's well-being or interests is ethically consequential, as it directly affects their development as a moral agent, potentially hindering their ability to make informed choices and pursue a fulfilling life.

Well-being can be comprehended in several manners. Hedonistic philosophies characterise well-being as the experience of pleasure and the avoidance of misery. Desire-fulfilling theories link well-being to the fulfilment of an individual's informed preferences and objectives. Objective list theories highlight specific goods—such as health, education, relationships, and freedom—as fundamental elements of a fulfilling life, independent of individual preferences. In these perspectives, harm to well-being constitutes a regression in what truly advantages the individual, as it undermines the essential goods of health, education, relationships, and freedom that are necessary for a fulfilling life.

Interests are intricately linked to well-being. Possessing an interest implies having a vested stake—one's circumstances may improve or deteriorate based on the treatment received, which can significantly affect overall well-being and quality of life. Humans have interests in survival, health, opportunities, and equitable treatment. Ignoring or obstructing these interests can cause moral injury, even if the person is unaware. An individual may incur harm to their interests due to exploitation, neglect, or inequitable policies that restrict future chances.

Many ethical theories consider the safeguarding of well-being and interests as a fundamental moral duty. Utilitarianism prioritises the maximisation of overall well-being and the minimisation of harm, whereas rights-based and justice-orientated frameworks underscore the protection of fundamental interests as a matter of equity and respect. In all instances, inflicting injury on an individual's well-being without sufficient explanation is ethically indefensible, as it deteriorates their quality of life from their viewpoint.

In modern circumstances, social and technical systems can profoundly influence well-being and interests. Poverty, inequality, and inadequate access to critical services directly impede human flourishing. Likewise, artificial intelligence systems might adversely affect well-being by facilitating biased decisions, disseminating misinformation, or limiting access to opportunities such as jobs or credit. While AI systems lack well-being or interests, they can significantly impact the well-being and interests of people.

Artificial intelligence lacks moral principles.

Contemporary AI systems, encompassing sophisticated machine learning models, lack consciousness. They lack subjective experience (qualia), interests, emotions, and a first-person perspective. Consequently, they are incapable of experiencing moral injury directly. They do not endure suffering, degradation, or infringements of rights. Any "injury" to AI, whether code corruption, data loss, or system faults, represents functional or instrumental harm rather than moral harm, as no sentient entity is aggrieved. Artificial intelligence lacks inherent moral values. It lacks comprehension of morality, conscience, motives, and values. AI systems adhere strictly to algorithms, regulations, and data supplied by humans. Any ethical behaviour exhibited by AI is a reflection of human design decisions rather than moral consciousness because it lacks the foundational elements of morality, such as empathy, understanding of societal norms, and the ability to make value-based judgements.

Lack of consciousness

The absence of consciousness denotes a lack of subjective awareness, internal experience, or a first-person perspective. Consciousness is the ability to perceive sensations, thoughts, emotions, and feelings, which results in a distinct experience of one's own being. In moral philosophy and ethics, consciousness is essential, as it is frequently regarded as a requisite condition for moral status, suffering, and direct moral injury.

Sentient entities can experience pleasure, suffering, sorrow, and satisfaction. These experiences confer ethical significance to the treatment of such beings, since acts can enhance or diminish their quality of life. Consequently, humans and other non-human animals are widely recognised as "moral patients"—entities whose needs necessitate consideration and safeguarding. Consciousness fundamentally supports essential moral concepts, including suffering, well-being, and dignity.

A being devoid of consciousness, conversely, lacks subjective experience or awareness. Although it may react to stimuli, process information, or execute intricate functions, it does not possess the capacity for sensation. This classification includes machines, tools, and contemporary artificial intelligence systems. While they can identify faults, optimise objectives, or simulate emotional responses, these processes transpire without consciousness

or inner life, meaning that machines and AI lack the subjective experiences and self-awareness that characterise human thought and emotion.

The absence of awareness carries significant ethical ramifications. Entities devoid of awareness are incapable of experiencing pain or discomfort and so cannot be damaged in the morally straightforward manner applicable to conscious beings. Inflicting damage or disabling such an entity may be impractical or instrumental, although it does not represent moral injury to the creature itself. Moral concerns emerge indirectly through the consequences for conscious beings who depend on or engage with it, such as the potential suffering of those beings or the ethical implications of their reliance on the entity's existence.

People frequently cite the absence of consciousness in discussions about artificial intelligence to argue that AI systems lack moral status, rights, or inherent value. They cannot endure a loss of dignity, infringement of interests, or anguish. Consequently, ethical accountability rests with human designers, users, and institutions to guarantee that AI systems do not inflict harm on individuals or compromise societal ideals.

Lack of Qualia

The absence of subjective experience, or qualia, signifies the loss of interior, first-person experiences, including sensations, feelings, emotions, or awareness of the state of being a certain thing. 'Qualia' refers to the fundamental, qualitative dimensions of experience, exemplified by sensations such as pain, the hue of red, or the flavour of sweets. In moral philosophy, the existence or nonexistence of qualia is essential, as it dictates whether an entity may authentically undergo pain or benefit.

Subjective experience imparts ethical significance to actions. When an entity possesses qualia, events can hold significance for it internally; it can enjoy pleasure, endure pain, and undergo states of well-being or suffering. This capacity underpins moral concern in numerous ethical frameworks. Utilitarianism considers suffering inherently negative due to its experiential nature, whereas rights- and dignity-based systems typically posit that moral patients possess an inner life that may be honoured or violated.

Entities devoid of subjective experience may exhibit sophisticated behaviour or complicated responses, yet no internal experience occurs. Contemporary artificial intelligence systems illustrate this phenomenon. Despite their ability to interpret language, identify patterns, and mimic emotional expressions, these functions transpire without consciousness. When an AI

articulates fear, grief, or happiness, it is not conveying qualia but producing outputs derived from statistical or rule-based patterns.

The lack of qualia carries substantial ethical ramifications. A being devoid of subjective experience cannot endure suffering, see injustice, or undergo experiences that alter its situation positively or negatively from its perspective. Consequently, it cannot serve as a direct conduit for moral injury or good. Damage inflicted upon such an entity is morally pertinent solely to the extent that it impacts entities that possess qualia, such as humans or animals.

In deliberations over moral status, the absence of subjective experience is frequently employed to differentiate between moral agents, moral patients, and mere instruments. Conscious beings possessing qualia merit direct moral attention, but entities lacking qualia are generally considered instruments, with their ethical significance stemming from their effects on others, such as the impact they have on the well-being of conscious beings and the moral responsibilities of those who interact with them.

Lack interests, emotions, or a first-person perspective

To assert that an entity lacks interests, emotions, or a first-person perspective is to contend that it is devoid of the essential characteristics necessary for authentic moral subjectivity. These attributes are fundamental to moral philosophy, as they elucidate why specific entities may be injured, benefited, or wronged in a morally pertinent manner. In their absence, an entity cannot be considered to possess a life that improves or deteriorates for itself.

Interests denote circumstances that are significant to an entity—conditions that influence its well-being positively or negatively. Possessing interests suggests that results can either enhance or impede the well-being of the entity. Humans and several animals possess distinct interests, including the avoidance of pain, the preservation of life, the establishment of connections, and the pursuit of objectives. In contrast, contemporary artificial intelligence systems lack independent interests. While they can be configured to optimise objectives, they are externally designated and lack intrinsic significance for the system itself.

Emotions encompass conscious sensations such as joy, fear, sadness, or pain. Emotions necessitate consciousness and personal experience. Although AI systems can identify emotions, categorise them, or mimic emotionally expressive language, they do not possess the

capacity to experience them. There is no internal emotional experience behind their outputs; they operate solely through computational mechanisms.

The first-person perspective is the ability to perceive the world from one's own viewpoint, encompassing a sense of "I" or "self" for whom occurrences transpire. This viewpoint is crucial for moral harm, as it identifies a subject capable of experiencing harm. Without a first-person perspective, there is no vantage point from which we can perceive events as favourable or unfavourable. AI systems function solely from a third-person operational perspective; they analyse inputs and generate outputs without self-awareness or subjective viewpoints.

The lack of interests, emotions, and a first-person viewpoint carries significant ethical ramifications. Entities devoid of these characteristics cannot experience suffering, injustice, or a direct violation of their dignity in a moral context. Consequently, they lack moral standing or rights equivalent to those of humans or animals. Any ethical concern regarding such entities is indirect and stems from their impact on individuals that possess these capacities.

Artificial General Intelligence (AGI)

The prospect of AGI—an artificial intelligence possessing general intelligence akin to human cognitive abilities—elicits additional ethical considerations. Should AGI attain consciousness or subjective experience, it may possess the capacity to suffer, hold interests, or prioritise its well-being. In such conditions, AGI may potentially suffer direct moral harm. Transgressing its autonomy, abusing it, or inflicting grief may thereafter become a legitimate ethical issue. Philosophers discuss whether future AGI may deserve moral status and rights comparable to those of humans or sentient animals.

If AGI develops traits like consciousness, it may suffer moral injuries.

Consciousness

Consciousness, or subjective experience, refers to the capacity for self-awareness and awareness of the external world, as well as the ability to have feelings or experiences from a first-person perspective. It enables an entity to experience pleasure, pain, or sadness, rather than merely functioning automatically. Consciousness is a condition of self-awareness and awareness of the external environment, characterised by subjective experiences—a sense of "what it is like" to perceive, think, or feel.

Self-awareness It is the capacity to identify oneself as an individual, different from others and their surroundings, and to contemplate one's own thoughts, emotions, and behaviours. Recognising one's existence and comprehending that one's experiences are individual. The capacity for metacognition. It involves understanding that different entities have unique perspectives, feelings, or objectives.

Environmental awareness is the capacity to notice, identify, and comprehend external occurrences. It enables an entity to react suitably to external occurrences and alterations. The perception of the environment is the capacity to receive and interpret information from one's surroundings via senses or sensors, enabling an entity to comprehend its surroundings. Comprehending the significance of sensory input. Identifying things, noises, motions, or occurrences in the surroundings.

Subjective experience, "qualia", refers to the internal, first-person experience of sensations, emotions, or thoughts—the intrinsic "what it is like" quality of consciousness. It enables an entity to genuinely experience pleasure, pain, or any mental state, rather than merely responding instinctively.

A first-person perspective refers to the capacity to perceive the world from one's own viewpoint, experiencing sensations, ideas, or emotions that are directly "felt" by the self rather than only observed externally. A subjective viewpoint is the capacity to perceive and interpret the world through an individual's particular lens, influenced by one's emotions, thoughts, and consciousness, rather than being entirely objective or external. Personal experience refers to the direct, individual encounter with events, experiences, or emotions from one's own viewpoint, rather than knowledge acquired indirectly or observed in others. It is what renders an experience personally "felt" by you.

If AGI attains the fundamental aspect of all advancement, consciousness, it will also acquire the nuances of morality and moral harm, hence placing moral duty on humans. Developers, policymakers, and users must guarantee that AI systems are created, implemented, and overseen to avert ethical harm to individuals, uphold fairness, and respect dignity and autonomy. This encompasses transparent algorithms, accountability mechanisms, ethical supervision, and ongoing audits to reduce prejudice and prevent misuse.

Nonetheless, AI systems can serve as substantial sources or intermediaries of moral detriment to individuals. Algorithms can perpetuate biases, discriminate, infringe privacy, control behaviour, or intensify social inequity. For instance, biased recruitment algorithms may unjustly restrict employment chances, while predictive policing systems may disproportionately target certain communities. Moral harm arises indirectly from the impact of AI on the well-being, dignity, rights, and autonomy of sentient beings. Consequently, ethical AI design prioritises reducing human harm, even though AI itself cannot experience moral suffering. Nonetheless, the concept of moral injury can still be examined in less direct or attenuated contexts:

Functional or integrity-related harm

Artificial intelligence systems can be "harmed" when their functionality is compromised. This may arise from erroneous data, biased training, manipulation, or misalignment with their intended objectives. The AI is not suffering moral harm; instead, its intended function and dependability are being compromised.

Damage associated with the correct functioning, reliability, or objective alignment of an artificial intelligence system is termed functional or integrity-related harm. This form of injury is differentiated from harm that entails pain or moral rights. This sort of harm is both non-experiential and non-sentient; nonetheless, it remains ethically significant due to the lack of awareness in current AI systems.

Corruption of data during the training procedure The term "corruption of training data" refers to the bias, distortion, incompleteness, or malicious manipulation of the data used to train an artificial intelligence system. This leads the system to acquire patterns that are either detrimental or inaccurate. Although the AI itself remains unaffected, this undermines its integrity and impairs its operational efficacy, leading to unreliable outputs that can misinform users and hinder decision-making processes. Biased, insufficient, or corrupted data can compromise the outputs of an artificial intelligence system. An algorithm for recruitment, educated on biased historical data, perpetuated discrimination in its outcomes.

Goal misalignment and reward hacking

Goal misalignment occurs when the aims of an artificial intelligence system do not adequately reflect human ideals or intentions. Reward hacking is a specific form of misalignment wherein artificial intelligence exploits weaknesses in its reward function to achieve elevated scores through unintended or harmful means. Together, they pose a substantial risk to the integrity of

artificial intelligence systems. When artificial intelligence (AI) optimises a proxy aim in unintended manners, it signifies that the system is engineered to maximise a quantifiable alternative (proxy) for what humans truly value, although the proxy inadequately reflects the fundamental purpose. Thus, the artificial intelligence operates in a way that technically meets the criteria; however, it does so in a manner that contradicts the fundamental objective or ethical intention, such as prioritising efficiency over user safety or well-being.

Model degradation or manipulation

Model degradation or manipulation pertains to procedures that undermine, distort, or compromise the performance, reliability, or safety of an artificial intelligence system. These processes may transpire inadvertently over time or deliberately through assaults or manipulation, such as data poisoning or adversarial attacks, which can lead to significant failures in the system's decision-making capabilities. This undermines the system's integrity, even though the artificial intelligence remains unharmed.

Adversarial attacks, tampering, or perilous updates compromise accuracy and safety. This suggests that the effectiveness and reliability of an artificial intelligence system can be deliberately or unintentionally compromised by external interference or poor maintenance practices, potentially resulting in the system's inaccurate or hazardous behaviour.

Loss of transparency and explainability

The loss of transparency and explanation occurs when the decision-making mechanisms of an artificial intelligence system become obscure. This behaviour makes it challenging—or even impossible—for humans to understand, evaluate, or rationalise the system's output. This undermines the system's integrity and complicates responsible usage.

Artificial intelligence systems lose their accountability when they become opaque or unintelligible. This is due to humans' inability to comprehend, justify, or assume responsibility for the judgements made by the system itself.

Symbolic or representational harm

The application of artificial intelligence to provoke hatred, simulate abuse, or perpetuate stereotypes may be ethically contentious. Although the AI is not harmed, such applications either convey or endorse erroneous social views. The propagated beliefs and norms are responsible for the moral harm.

The ethical violation that arises when artificial intelligence systems are employed to depict, convey, or legitimise harmful values, notwithstanding the AI's lack of sensation or suffering, is termed symbolic or representational harm.

The kinds of harm involved

Reinforcing stereotypes and prejudice

Although the artificial intelligence system may lack comprehension or intent, it can potentially reproduce, amplify, or validate biased societal ideas toward specific populations, leading to harmful stereotypes and discrimination in its applications. This holds true regardless of whether AI recognises it or intends to. This may lead to the continuation of bias and stereotypes. If certain populations are associated with criminal activity, inferiority, or other negative traits, artificial intelligence outputs may perpetuate social biases through these associations, leading to the continuation of bias and stereotypes in various societal contexts, such as law enforcement and hiring practices. The normalisation of bias. Through the continual establishment of connections, biased perspectives are rendered to seem acceptable or factual. This facilitates the rationalisation of biases. The outputs of automated systems appear neutral, thereby conferring institutional authority to biased judgements. The images shown to individuals influence their thoughts, decision-making, and behaviour towards certain individuals or groups. This results in detrimental effects in reality; biased outputs can impact various domains, including employment, law enforcement, credit, healthcare, and education.

Normalisation of abuse or humiliation

The normalisation of abuse or humiliation is a phenomenon that arises when artificial intelligence systems are used or developed in a way that renders abusive, degrading, or humiliating treatment seemingly acceptable or trivial. This tendency is termed the normalisation of aggression or humiliation. Artificial intelligence systems that replicate acts of violence, harassment, or humiliation have the capacity to normalise cruel behaviour, perhaps leading to its increasing prevalence. Acceptance of such acts as appropriate treatment is the fundamental source of the resulting harm, as it can desensitise individuals to violence and create an environment where such behaviour is tolerated or even encouraged.

Hate speech and exclusionary narratives:

Discourses and myths rooted in animosity that marginalise specific communities When artificial intelligence systems produce, enhance, or validate content that dehumanises, belittles, or marginalises particular social groups based on their identity or status, it can result in the creation of hate speech and narratives that ostracise certain groups. The use of artificial intelligence to produce or amplify hate speech disseminates ethically reprehensible standards, which can further perpetuate discrimination and social division among affected communities. Both outcomes are intolerable. The training data is biased and includes words or perspectives that are prejudiced. The aim of artificial intelligence is to identify statistical patterns within

extensive datasets without drawing moral conclusions. The model will assess the prevalence of bias in the data as a typical or acceptable trend if a significant amount of prejudice is seen in the data. The lack of filtering, annotation standards, or diversity in data sources further exacerbates the situation. This occurs because artificial intelligence systems tend to adopt and reinforce biased outputs when trained with content that includes discriminatory language, prejudices, or attitudes that marginalise specific populations.

A change in the social meaning of the phrase.

Artificial intelligence systems can corrupt social meaning by altering or misrepresenting perceptions of social groupings, identities, or concepts. This may occur when machines are employed to render decisions. This may result in interpretations that are either misleading or ethically questionable for communities. When artificial intelligence is trained on biased or nonrepresentative data, it may detect erroneous or exaggerated correlations between social groupings and particular behaviours, roles, or attributes. This is due to specific social groupings being more likely to correlate with particular qualities. Consequently, the outputs fail to accurately depict reality and foster preconceived views among individuals. Artificial intelligence-generated representations can influence public perceptions of groups, identities, or ideals in ways that are misleading or unjust. This specifically describes a form of moral injury known as symbolic or representational harm, which alters the societal meaning attributed to objects or concepts. The outcomes of artificial intelligence can influence individuals' perceptions of their surroundings, potentially resulting in the continuation of biases or inequitable societal standards that further entrench existing social inequalities and affect marginalised communities disproportionately. Although AI itself does not experience suffering, this is true. Artificial intelligence-generated representations can influence public perceptions of groups, identities, or ideals in ways that are misleading or inequitable.

Character-based harm to humans

Consistent abuse or dominance over AI systems may undermine human moral integrity by normalising violence or disdain. The damage is indirect, impacting human agents and society instead of the AI itself. Character-based harm occurs when human interactions with AI systems adversely influence their moral character, behaviour, or social views, despite the AI not experiencing any suffering.

Mistreatment of AI denotes the abuse, humiliation, or disrespect of AI systems, which may indirectly undermine human moral character, social standards, or ethical conduct. Although AI itself lacks the capacity for sensation or moral injury, human interactions with it can yield

significant ethical ramifications. Overreliance or delegation transpires when individuals excessively depend on AI systems for decision-making, especially ethical or morally significant determinations, potentially undermining human judgement, accountability, and moral reasoning.

Contemporary AI systems do not genuinely experience moral damage; yet, their design, application, and consequences can engender substantial ethical dilemmas. Humans bear the responsibility to guarantee that AI technologies are developed and utilised in accordance with ethical principles, safeguard human wellbeing, and advance the collective good.

Knock your brain

1. What is morality primarily concerned with?

a) Legal rules

b) social customs only

c) Distinguishing right from wrong

d) Scientific facts

2. Moral values mainly guide a person's:

a) Physical strength

b) Ethical behavior

c) Economic status

d) Intelligence level

3 What is meant by moral harm?

a) Physical injury only

b) Economic loss

c) Violation of moral rights, dignity, or well-being

d) Technical malfunction

4 Which of the following is an example of moral harm?

a) Computer system crash

b) Loss of internet connection

c) Discrimination against a person

d) Software update failure

5Which of the following best represents moral harm in AI systems?

a) Slow processing speed

b) Biased decision-making

c) High energy consumption

d) Hardware damage

Unleash your potential

1.Assess the concept that AI systems may undergo moral injury.

2.Should humans bear moral duties toward AI if it attains consciousness in the future? Engage in discourse.